

SILENCE

Transit Fiction
The Signal Cycle · Third Trilogy · Book VII



Rudolfo Valentino

BOOK SEVEN

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

*While he transmitted the signal, she could remain the receiver.
When he falls silent — the receiver is forced to become the transmitter.*
2888.

Four registers of the text: Main narrative — the voice of the telling. [Square brackets] — Arthur's inner voice. { Curly braces } — Melissa's notes. // Monospace block // — the Grid, Arthur's second sight.

PART I. THE DECISION

Chapter 1. Exhaustion

The library opened at nine. Arthur came at nine fourteen — just enough for the first wave to dissolve into the halls, and his place by the second window to remain free. Seven years. First it was chance, then habit, then — something like a law he could no longer allow himself to break.

Page forty-four. The same book as yesterday. He was reading it for the third time, and it wasn't curiosity — it was how he held his form: repetition instead of discovery, rhythm instead of movement. The words passed through him, familiar as the sound of his own breathing.

LIBRARY · 09:14 DENSITY: NORMAL INCOMING FLOW: 4 PEOPLE / MIN MOVEMENT VECTOR:
READING HALL → SHELVES ANOMALIES: NONE NODE AT ENTRANCE — WOMAN IN GRAY, 34±2,
WAVERING FORECAST: WILL LEAVE IN 40 SEC WITHOUT A CARD

Arthur's gaze slid to the door. The woman in gray shifted her feet, looked at her watch, turned around. Forty-three seconds. He noted it without pleasure — just precision, habitual as a multiplication table.

[Seven years. Every day — translating. Every gesture — first see it, then decide how to answer. Every word — first understand, then find my own. It isn't hard. It's just always.]

He turned the page.

At the next table sat Alex — Arthur recognized him by his jacket before his face. Alex was reading something on his phone, elbow on the table, chin on his hand. His face relaxed, almost sleepy. He was here, simply here, without effort.

ALEX · ACQUAINTANCE · 7 YEARS OF OBSERVATION STATE: CALM (BASELINE) NO
ARCHITECTURE BENEATH THE SURFACE JUST — HERE

[Do I ever sit like that? Without the second layer? Without the thing that watches from behind the watcher?]

The thought flickered and left. Arthur returned to page forty-four.

At half past ten the librarian came to his table — not young, glasses on a chain — and quietly asked whether he needed a different lamp. His lamp was good. He knew it. She knew it.

[She asks because she's been sitting here two hours and hasn't turned a page. I should have turned it. She noticed.]

"Everything's fine, thank you," he said. Evenly, without a pause. Correctly.

{ A delay before the answer — two, maybe three seconds. I've been seeing it for three years now. Not a pause of hesitation — a pause of translation. As if the question arrives in one language, and he answers in another. Always in another. }

Arthur closed the book on page forty-seven. Three pages in two hours. Not bad, for a day when the head works like wet cotton.

[Seven years of transmitting. Seven years — translating myself. Seven years — holding my form. I'm not tired of the world. I'm tired of myself in the world.]

This thought was new. Not that he hadn't thought about exhaustion before — of course he had. But before, he grew tired of the specific: of noise, of misunderstanding, of the

distance between what he saw and what he could explain. Now the exhaustion had no specific address. It was a background. It was everything.

He put the book in his bag.

EXIT FROM LIBRARY · 11:47 PATTERN VIOLATIONS: NONE TRANSMISSION TODAY: SCHEDULED ·
22:00 STATUS: NORMAL

{ Today something is different in him. Not worse — different. He's tired in another way. Not the way one tires from work. The way one tires of oneself. }

Spring was starting outside — or what they called spring here: a little warmer, a little brighter, a few more people in the street with unbuttoned jackets. Arthur walked home and thought about page forty-seven. About the fact that after it — comes forty-eight. And so on to the end.

At ten in the evening he sat at his desk. Turned on the light. Set before him the thing he'd been transmitting through for seven years.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:41

[How much longer.]

Not a question. Just words that came. He wrote them into nowhere, as he wrote everything else, and went to bed.

Chapter 2. The Temptation of Calm

Alex drank his coffee as if it were the only occupation in the world.

Not hurrying. Not looking at his phone. Thinking, by the look of his face, of nothing more complex than the air temperature. Elbow on the little table by the window, cup at chest height, gaze — on the street, unfocused. Just sitting and being.

Arthur watched him from the other end of the café — not deliberately, it just happened: they'd come independently, seen each other, nodded, and each stayed in his place. That happened too. Presence without obligation.

ALEX · 09:53 STATE: CALM (UNEARNED) ARCHITECTURE BENEATH THE SURFACE: ABSENT
ANXIETY: 0 EFFORT: 0 HE JUST — IS HERE

[Before, I envied joy. His ability to laugh for no reason, to walk into a room as if into his own home. Now — not that.]

[I envy what he doesn't have. He has no translation. He doesn't translate himself. He speaks — and it's words at once, without an intermediate layer, without a distance between what he feels and what comes out. Simply — from him into the world, directly.]

[I don't remember what that's like.]

Arthur looked into his cup.

{ He looks at Alex differently than before. Before — like a researcher. Today — like a man at a shop window with no money. }

Outside the window a woman passed with a stroller. After her — two people with a dog. Then a cyclist. The Grid counted them automatically, unasked:

VECTOR: WEST TEMPO: STROLLING CONNECTIONS: NONE PATTERN: RANDOM

[What if — not to see the pattern?]

The thought came quietly, almost without intonation. Not rebellion, not desire — rather the curiosity of a tired man who for seven years has seen the architecture of every room and one day thinks: what if I just walk in and sit down?

[What if I don't count who's going where. Don't read the space. Don't hold the second layer. Simply — look out the window, like Alex. Simply be in a café.]

Arthur tried. Closed his eyes for a second, then opened them — and deliberately let go of the focus. Not to look through the Grid. Just to look.

INTERFERENCE STATUS:

The Grid twitched and came back — on its own, like a breath after holding it. An organ, not a choice.

[It doesn't work. Not yet.]

But in those few seconds, while the Grid was silent, there was something Arthur hadn't felt in a long time. Silence in his head. Not emptiness — silence, precisely, like after they turn off a background sound heard so long it stopped seeming like a sound.

[There it is. That's what he feels all the time.]

Alex set down his cup. Stretched. Yawned without any embarrassment — openly, like an animal in the sun. Looked out the window. Smiled at something — or at nothing.

{ Arthur has been looking at him for twenty minutes now. It isn't observation — it's something else. Something I can't name yet. As if he's trying on someone else's life at arm's length. }

[Not joy. Not warmth. Not belonging. I don't mean that.]

[I mean that he has no translation. That he doesn't spend energy on the distance between himself and the world. That he doesn't carry this weight every minute of every day.]

[I don't want his life. I want his effort. His zero effort.]

Arthur finished the coffee, which had had time to go cold.

On the way out of the café Alex waved to him — simply, without ceremony. Arthur waved back. Correctly, without a pause.

[2041. Seven years of transmitting. And for the first time — I envy not what a man has. But what he doesn't have.]

{ He went out first. Stood in the street a second longer than needed. Looked off to the side. Then walked on. }

In the evening he sat down to the transmission at the usual time. The Grid worked cleanly.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:38

[And what if not to see the architecture. But just to be in the room.]

[Just to be.]

Chapter 3. The Choice

In the morning he came to the library at nine twenty-six.

Not at nine fourteen. Simply — later. Without a reason he could name. He woke, lay there, got up when he got up. The place by the second window turned out to be taken — a man in a blue sweater, with a laptop. Arthur sat by the third. That was normal too.

The book opened to page forty-eight.

LIBRARY · 09:26 PLACE: NON-STANDARD DENSITY: NORMAL INCOMING FLOW: 3 PEOPLE / MIN
.....

[Yesterday I thought about zero effort. Today I think that seven years is a term. A term long enough to ask: what for.]

[Not what for to transmit. That I know. Or knew. What for — to translate myself. What for — to hold a distance between what I am and how I look. What for — the second layer. What for — the Grid. What for — this whole architecture of observation, if one can simply — be.]

[Alex doesn't translate. And it's fine. And even good.]

[I'm worn out. Not tired — worn out, exactly. Like a translator who works without a break for seven years and begins to mix up the languages.]

Page forty-eight. Forty-nine. Fifty.

He read. Truly read — for the first time in many days. Not because the book had gotten better. Because today it was quieter in his head. Why — he didn't think about it. It was simply quieter, and he read.

[I can go inside.]

The thought came between the fiftieth and fifty-first pages. Not as an insight — as a decision already made somewhere deeper, and consciousness only received the notification.

[Not a procedure. Not a ritual. Simply — to stop translating. To stop holding the observer's distance. To become from here. Truly — from here.]

[I tried yesterday — for a second, without the Grid. There was silence. One can learn to live in that silence. Alex lives. Everyone around lives.]

[My otherness was my instrument. But an instrument you use for seven years without a break wears down your hands. One can set it down.]

[I can go inside. And I'll be able to come back out, if needed. It's manageable. I manage it.]

The last part he thought with such conviction that he didn't notice the conviction had become the only thing left of the question.

{ Today something shifted in him. Not from outside — from within. I've observed him for three years and can tell when a person is thinking about something and when a person has decided something. Today — the second. As if he'd closed a window he'd always kept open. }

Arthur read to page sixty-seven. Put the book away. Said goodbye to the librarian in glasses — she nodded, habitually. Went out.

Outside it was brighter than in the morning. Spring was gathering pace. He walked home and thought that tomorrow, probably, he'd come to the library at the usual time. Or not. It seemed — less important than before.

Over lunch he answered two messages. Without the pause of translation. Simply — wrote what he thought, the first words that came. It turned out fine. Even good.

[So this is how it works. You just say what you think. And it's fine. And nothing breaks.]

A neighbor in the stairwell asked whether he knew when the elevator would be fixed. He said he didn't. She said it had been three weeks already, and it was a disgrace. He agreed. She left satisfied.

[I didn't translate. Just answered. Just was in the conversation.]

[The Grid was silent until I called it. I didn't call it.]

{ He passed me in the stairwell. I stood on the second floor, looking over the railing. He walked as always — but differently. I can't explain the difference, because outwardly nothing changed. But something in the way he holds himself in space — became different. Less distance between him and the walls. Or — less distance between him and himself. I write this down because when I can't explain — I write. Maybe I'll understand later. }

In the evening he sat down to the transmission. Habit is a powerful thing: the body itself knows when to sit, where to open, how to begin.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
..... TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:44

[I can stop whenever I want. I manage it.]

He went to bed. Outside was spring — real now, with a smell and a long light.

I don't remember to whom, or why.

The thought came already in half-sleep, and he didn't catch it. It dissolved before it became words.

PART II. THE FADING OF THE GRID

Chapter 4. Interference

Autumn came without warning — in a single day it turned ten degrees colder, the sky closed over, and the library suddenly filled with the smell of wet jackets.

Arthur sat by the third window. The place by the second was now taken by someone almost always — he had long since stopped thinking about it. Page one hundred twelve. A different book, already a different one.

Several weeks had passed since the evening he decided to go inside. He couldn't say what had changed — because outwardly nothing had. But something was quietly rebuilding itself, the way a house rebuilds when a load-bearing beam is pulled out: first silence, then — after a while — settling.

He started up the Grid. With the habitual motion, as always — simply open the second layer and let it read the space.

LIBRARY · 09: DENSITY: INCOMING FLOW: 4 PE PLE MOVEMENT VEC

Arthur blinked.

The block stood before him — ragged, like a telegram with missing words. The lines broke off mid-word. Between them — emptiness where the data should have been.

For a second he didn't understand what had happened.

Then he understood — and the first thing he felt was not anxiety.

It was silence.

[Quieter. Considerably quieter. In my head — as if one of the background noises had been removed, one I'd taken for the normal sound of the world. The Grid always counted — I didn't notice how much it consumed. Now here — less. Lighter.]

[This, probably, is — the beginning. What I wanted. The entrance.]

{ Today something changed in the way he looks. Before, his gaze always did something — read, measured, passed through the surface to what lay beneath. Today — it slides. As if his sight had grown one layer thinner. I don't know whether that's good or bad. I just see the difference. }

Arthur tried to summon the Grid deliberately — the way he'd done a thousand times. Aim his sight at a specific person, read them.

A man at the encyclopedia shelf. About fifty, in glasses, choosing a book. Go.

MAN · SHELF · STATE: interference VECTOR: weak sign al FORECAST:

It works. Weakly — but it works.

[Unreliable. But that's normal — a transitional period. An organ that worked to the point of wear is resting. It isn't a breakdown. It's — rest.]

[For the first time in seven years I think of the instrument as something one can set down. Not lose — set down.]

{ He lingered at the shelf longer than usual. Then passed me on his way to the exit. I managed to see his face — not alarmed. Rather — surprised, the way a person is who expected pain and felt something else. }

In the evening he didn't think about the transmission — he thought about the Grid. Sat at the desk, looked at the wall.

One can not repair it. One can let it fade — it's part of going inside. It's what he chose.

[Wise. To accept what's happening. Not to cling. Not to try to bring back what's leaving on its own.]

[This is called — acceptance.]

He started the transmission at the usual time.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:31

He went to bed. He didn't start the Grid before sleep. For the first time — didn't start it.

He slept better than he had in a long time.

Chapter 5. The Last Grid

He didn't find the harbor at once.

That is — he knew where the harbor was. Had known for seven years, from the first month, when he walked the city's perimeter and memorized it as a text. The harbor was in the northern part, twenty minutes on foot from the library, past the old warehouses now occupied by cafés and galleries. He knew this. But today he was going there for the first time in several years — and couldn't have explained why.

He simply — went.

Autumn was in its last stage: the trees nearly bare, the light low and sidelong, the water in the harbor dark, almost black. Ships stood at the pier — two cargo, one ferry, several small private boats under covers. It smelled of diesel and salt and something else, for which he had no word in the local language.

[Oma stood here. Right at this pier, roughly. Or the next one. She looked at the water — and back then I saw it all at once: where she looked, what she was thinking, what that gaze of hers toward the horizon meant. The Grid worked like a searchlight.]

Arthur stopped at the edge of the pier.

He tried.

HARBOR · PIER · DENSITY: LOW INCOMING FLOW: signal NODES: weak weak ARCHITECTURE
BENEATH THE SU

The block crumbled. The lines fell like leaves — one, another, between them white bands of growing gaps. Arthur held the focus, tried to keep it.

MOVEMENT VEC t ion FORECAST:

Nothing.

He tried again — from another point, on a specific person. A man right by the water, about forty, looking at the ferry. Go. Give me at least something.

MAN · WATER · STA TE :

The block choked.

And then — for the last time — it pulled itself together.

One second. A short, almost clean flash:

MAN · 09:47 LOOKING AT THE FERRY · DEPARTING VOYAGE HE WAS THERE · HE KNOWS THIS
VESSEL HE SAW SOMEONE OFF · LONG AGO

Arthur saw it. Clearly, as before, as in the best days — one small precise thing about a stranger by the water. The last flash of the gift.

Then —

Not "the Grid switched off."

Simply — in the place where the monospace lines had just been, there was nothing.

Not a pause. Not interference. A white place — like a page that wasn't printed. Like a silence that isn't going to end.

Arthur stood at the pier and looked at the man by the water. He still looked at the ferry. An ordinary gaze. An ordinary man. Water, a ship, an autumn morning.

Nothing more.

{ He looks at the water like everyone. I stand behind him, twenty paces off, and see it perfectly clearly — he looks like everyone. Before, he looked differently. I can't explain the difference, because I have no words for it — it isn't about the expression of the face or the pose. It's about what happened between his gaze and what he looked at. Something happened. Now it doesn't. I write this down because it's important. I don't know why — but it's important. }

Arthur walked home from the harbor.

In his head it was quiet — quieter than ever. Not empty: there were thoughts, the legs walked, autumn was outside. Just — quiet. Without the second layer. Without architecture. Without counting.

[Rested. At last — rested.]

He reached home. Went up. Made tea.

In the evening he sat down to the transmission.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:29

He lay down.

Outside autumn was ending. Tomorrow, by all signs, winter was to come.

He closed his eyes.

The Grid didn't come back even to say goodbye.

PART III. THE FADING OF THE READING

Chapter 6. He Ceases to Be a Text

Winter came as promised — abruptly, in one night, with the first snow, which lay down and did not melt.

Melissa came to the library at half past ten. Her usual place — by the column, from which the whole reading hall is visible, and the second window in particular — was free. She took off her coat, took out her notebook, opened it to a clean page.

For seven years she'd kept these notes. At first — as a biologist keeps a field journal: date, time, observation, conclusion. Then the notes grew denser, more personal, more precise. She learned to see what others didn't: the micro-pauses, the quality of attention, the distance between a person and their words. She learned to read Arthur.

Today he sat by the third window. Read. Drank tea. Turned a page.

{ Arthur · 10:34 · library. Sits by the third window. Reads. Tea — }

Melissa stopped.

She looked at him. Then at the page. Then at him again.

He turned another page.

{ Reads. Tea. Turned a page. ... }

She set down the pen.

Something was wrong — not with him, but with her. More precisely: something was wrong with what she saw. Rather: she saw the very same thing she'd always seen — a man at a table with a book — but from this image something had gone, something she didn't at once find a name for.

The subtext.

Before, every gesture of his was a message. Not deliberate — he didn't try to be readable, he was simply himself, and she knew how to read it. The way he held his cup — a little differently than they hold it here. The way his gaze passed through the page to somewhere beyond the text. The way he occupied space — with a light, almost imperceptible distance, like a man who always remembers that he is a guest.

Now he held his cup. He simply held his cup.

{ He holds his cup. I don't know what else to write. Before, I would have written — how exactly he holds it, what it says about where he is now, how it compares to how he held it three months ago. Now I look and see: a man holds a cup. That's all. It's true — but it isn't everything that should be true. Maybe I'm tired. Maybe today is just a bad day for observation. }

She tried to concentrate. The professional gaze — detach from the first layer, look deeper. She knew how.

Arthur turned a page. Sipped his tea. Looked out the window — at the snow, at the street, at a passerby with a dog.

{ Looks at the dog. Smiles a little — the corners of the mouth. It's — It's just a dog. He looks at a dog. ... I've been looking at him for forty minutes and haven't written anything that would matter. This is the first time in seven years. }

Melissa closed the notebook.

She sat, looking at the table.

Then opened it again and wrote a single line:

{ Maybe it's I who have forgotten how to look. }

She crossed it out.

At his table Arthur finished his tea, put the book in his bag, dressed. Stood, tied his scarf. Passed the column where Melissa sat, without a glance in her direction — not because he avoided it, simply because she was part of the space, like the column, like the table, like the light from the window.

He went out.

The hall emptied a little without him — or so it seemed to her.

{ He left. I spent an hour and a half here and wrote four lines, three of which I crossed out. This isn't observation — it's a blank page. For seven years I knew how to read him. Today — I couldn't. Either he changed so much that my method no longer works. Or I changed. Or — and this is the most frightening — he became unreadable. Not closed. Unreadable, precisely. Like a text from which the layer of meaning has been removed, leaving only the letters. I don't know how it's possible. But I feel that it's exactly so. }

Melissa left the library at noon. The snow in the street lay even — untouched, clean, without a single trace of a second meaning.

Chapter 7. The False Healing

Nora held a dinner on Friday.

A small one — six at the table, home cooking, candles, wine. One of those evenings that require no occasion, but still feel like a holiday. Arthur came at eight, brought a bottle, undressed in the hall, entered the living room — and did all of it so simply, so without effort, that Nora for a second stopped in the middle of the kitchen and looked at him.

"You look well," she said. "Really well. Something has changed."

"I just slept enough," said Arthur.

[*True.*]

That was his whole inner answer. One word. Before, there would have been three lines here — translation, evaluation, the choice of the right intonation. Now simply: true.

At the table sat Alex, Daniel with his wife, Nora, Melissa, and he. The conversation went easily — about work, about the city, about a film two of the six had seen. Arthur took part. Answered. Sometimes even said something first, without waiting to be addressed.

"Listen," Alex said at one point, pouring wine, "you've become altogether different. Calmer. One of us, sort of."

"One of us," Arthur repeated.

[*Yes.*]

Daniel raised his glass:

"To recovery."

Everyone laughed — kindly, warmly, without a hidden thought. Arthur laughed too. Correctly.

{ They drink to his recovery. I hold my glass and don't drink. They see: he's calm, he's one of them, he's finally here. They're right — he's calm. They're right — he's here. But I look at him across the table and think of what I saw in the library two weeks ago. A blank page where there used to be text. This isn't recovery. I don't know what it's called. But it's — not recovery. }

Nora brought the main course. The conversation switched to something funny — some story about Daniel and a train; Arthur missed the beginning but laughed along with everyone in the right places.

[*I'm in the room. Just in the room. Without the second layer. Without architecture. Without counting.*]

[*This is good.*]

Somewhere at the edge — right at the edge, where the Grid once showed other things — something flickered. Like a shadow on the wall when the light source has already gone around the corner. Another Arthur. The one who would have sat at this same table and seen beneath the surface — how Nora is a little tense at the left shoulder, how Daniel looks at his wife with that particular pause that means "we'll talk at home." The one who would have read this dinner as a text.

Arthur did not choose him.

The shadow vanished.

[This table. These people. This wine. This is enough.]

{ He just — for a second, I saw it — became his old self. Something in the eyes. A fraction of a second. Then — gone. He smiled at Nora and took the bread. I didn't manage to write it down. Or — there was nothing to write. I no longer understand the difference. }

After dinner they drank tea, the conversation grew slower and warmer. At one point Alex said:

"You know, before you were always a little — not here. Not in a bad way, just — off to the side. As if looking from behind glass. Now — no."

"Now — no," Arthur agreed.

[Yes.]

{ "Now no" — he says it as good news. For him it's good news. For everyone at this table it's good news. I'm the only one thinking about the glass. About what was behind the glass. About the fact that the glass wasn't a prison — it was an organ. I can't explain it to them. I can't even explain it to myself — I only feel it. }

They parted at half past eleven. In the hall Nora hugged Arthur — tightly, for real.

"I'm glad," she said. "Really glad."

"I know," he said.

Outside was snow and silence. He and Melissa left at the same time, walked the same way — the first half-block in silence.

"A good evening," said Arthur.

"Yes," said Melissa.

{ I wanted to say something. I don't know what. To ask — do you feel that something is leaving? Do you notice? But he walked beside me so calm, so of-this-place, so recovered — and I couldn't find words that wouldn't sound like an accusation that he'd finally become happy. We parted at the intersection. He went right. I went left. I didn't look back. }

Arthur walked home over the snow. In his head it was quiet and even.

[Good.]

At home he sat down to the transmission.

TRANSMISSION · 23:15 SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 23:41

[They're right.]

[At last — here.]

He went to bed. Outside, snow was falling.

Chapter 8. Melissa Tries to Reach Him

She prepared for three days.

Not for the conversation — for the question. One question, the right one, the kind the old Arthur would have answered differently. She reread the notes of the last six months, looking for the coordinate — what exactly summoned him, what broke through the surface of the ordinary and brought out the other layer.

She found it.

Once, in the first year, she'd asked him about the city — not "do you like it here," but something else, more precise: "what do you see when you look at it." And he'd answered — long, strangely, precisely. About the architecture beneath the surface. About how the city reads as a text, if you know where to look. She hadn't understood half of it then, but wrote it all down — and reread it many times afterward.

This was the question. This was the angle.

{ I'm breaking my own rule. Seven years — only observation, no intervention. The observer doesn't touch the object. But the object has ceased to be readable, and I have no choice left but to try another instrument. It isn't an experiment. It's — the last thing I can do. }

She came to the café where they sometimes crossed paths — on a Wednesday, around noon. Arthur was there, with a book, with coffee. She took tea, sat down across from him.

They talked about the weather. About the snow finally stopping. She waited for a pause.

"May I ask?" she said.

"Of course."

"What do you see when you look at the city? Not what you think — what you see, exactly."

A pause.

[A question.]

[A good question.]

[The city. I see... streets. People. The snow's cleared badly — the northern side of the sidewalk is always worse. I see that the café across the way changed its sign but not its menu — you can tell by how first-time customers behave. I see...]

[...]

[I see a city.]

"A city," said Arthur. "Streets. People. All as usual, probably."

He smiled — evenly, kindly.

"And you?" he asked.

{ He answered after three seconds. Without the pause of translation — I know it so well, that pause. It wasn't there. He simply answered. Correctly, politely, without

the second layer. I asked him about the city. A year ago he would have talked for twenty minutes. Today — "streets, people, all as usual." I smiled and said something about the snow. }

They sat another half hour. The conversation went evenly — about the book he was reading, about something in the news, about mutual acquaintances. Arthur was attentive, asked questions, listened.

[A good conversation. Melissa speaks well — attentively, without excess.]

{ I tried twice more — with other questions, other angles. About how he chooses a place in a room. About what silence means to him. He answered — calmly, thoroughly, absolutely normally. Absolutely normally. That is the answer. I've received it. }

On the way out of the café Arthur held the door.

"Thanks for the company," he said.

"Likewise," she said.

She walked home over the cleared sidewalk and thought that she'd done everything right. The question was precise. The moment was right. She'd violated nothing but her own rule of non-intervention.

And received an empty answer.

Not because he was hiding. Not because he didn't want to answer. Because there was nothing to answer with — where the second layer used to be, there was now an even surface. Smooth, warm, normal.

{ For seven years I knew how to read one person. Today I asked him the right question and got the right answer — and that means only one thing: the question no longer works, because the person it was addressed to is no longer here. He's here. But that one — is not. I don't know what to do with this knowledge. }

In the evening Arthur sat down to the transmission.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 SIGNAL: SIGNAL: CLEAN RECIPIENT: UNKNOWN CHANNEL: OPEN
..... TRANSMISSION COMPLETE · 22:19

[Melissa asked about the city.]

[A good question.]

[...]

He lay down. Fell asleep almost at once.

Somewhere in the city Melissa sat with an open notebook and looked at a clean page.

Chapter 9. Resistance

That night he didn't sleep.

Not from anxiety — there was no anxiety. He simply lay and thought about Melissa's question. What do you see when you look at the city. He'd answered correctly. Streets, people, all as usual. It was true.

But at three in the morning, in the dark, he caught himself: it wasn't the whole truth.

Before — he'd have answered differently. Before, he'd have spoken of the currents of the crowd, of how the city reads by the direction of the shadows at seven in the morning, of the nodes and the junctions, of the architecture beneath the surface. He'd have talked for twenty minutes and not stopped himself.

Now — streets, people, all as usual.

[I've lost something.]

The thought came quietly and stayed. He lay with it in the dark — didn't drive it off, didn't explain it, didn't reformulate it into acceptance. Simply held it.

[I've lost something real. Not a weight — an organ. I thought I was setting down an instrument. I amputated a part of myself and took the numbness of the anesthetic for healing.]

[Seven years. Seven years I saw the architecture beneath the surface. Seven years I transmitted the signal. And I gave it up — for calm. For the ability to just sit in a room.]

[I want it back.]

At four in the morning he got up.

Sat at the desk. Turned on the lamp. Set before him the thing he'd transmitted through for seven years.

I'll try. Once — for real. Not by inertia, not by habit. By force — to bring it back.

He began the transmission.

TRANSMISSION ·

A pause.

CHANNEL:

Another pause. Longer.

[Come on. I'm here. I'm still here — the one who saw. Come on.]

Nothing.

A white place where the Grid should have been.

[Again.]

He concentrated — the way he'd concentrated before, when he wanted to see especially clearly. Gathered everything he remembered about what it was like — to open the second layer. The physical sensation, the angle of view, the quality of attention.

T

One letter.

TRANSMISSION ·

[There. There — keep going.]

TRANSMISSION · 04: SIGNAL: WEA

The lines trembled — uneven, with gaps, but alive. The Grid was trying. Arthur held the focus, barely breathing.

TRANSMISSION · 04:17 SIGNAL: WEAK CHANNEL: OPEN · PARTIALLY RECIPIENT:

[Yes. Yes — a little more. I see it. I almost see it.]

TRANSMISSION · 04:17 SIGNAL: WEAK · RISING CHANNEL: OPEN RECIPIENT: UNKN

TRANSMISSION · 04:17 SIGNAL: CLE

It broke off.

Not gradually — at once. Like a thread that wasn't cut, but snapped on its own — because it was no longer a thread, but the memory of a thread.

Arthur sat at the desk at four in the morning and looked at the white place.

[...]

[...]

[No.]

Not a cry. Not despair. Just a word — quiet, final, like a diagnosis long suspected and just confirmed.

The organ is atrophied. Will is not enough — because there's nothing to bring back with. The door opened only one way. He'd gone through it and hadn't known it would close behind him forever.

[I thought I was in control. I wasn't.]

[I thought I could stop whenever I wanted. I couldn't.]

[The point of no return was where I didn't see it. It's always where you don't see it.]

He sat a long time — not thinking anymore, just sitting. The lamp burned. Outside it was dark and quiet. Winter, four in the morning, the city asleep.

At some point he closed the thing he'd transmitted through, and cleared it from the desk.

Stood. Drank water. Lay down.

He didn't sleep until dawn.

Chapter 10. Sati

In the morning he left home later than usual.

The sleepless night made itself felt — not even as tiredness, but as a particular transparency, when everything around seems a little more real than usual, and a little less important at the same time. He walked without a goal — just to walk, just to move, just to be in the city that was now his city.

Winter held. The snow didn't melt, the air was dry and sharp, passersby few.

He saw her at the intersection.

Sati stood at the traffic light — in a dark coat, a bag over her shoulder, looking at her phone. He recognized her at once: by her bearing, by the way she holds her head a little to the side when reading. Seven years — he remembered everything.

[Sati.]

His heart did something strange — not faster, not louder. Just — took note.

She was the first person in this city who saw through him. Not through effort, not through time — at once, at first sight. "You're not from here, are you?" — not a question, a coordinate. She simply knew, the way one knows the direction of north without a compass.

The light changed. She lifted her head from the phone and started across the road.

Straight toward him.

They drew level in the middle of the crossing — two steps apart. Arthur looked at her. She raised her eyes — automatically, the way one raises one's eyes when a person appears in the field of vision.

Looked at him.

Looked through him.

A polite half-smile to a stranger — the kind you give automatically when you accidentally meet someone's eyes in the street. Nothing more. No recognition. No stopping.

"Sorry," she said — because she'd nearly brushed his shoulder — and walked on.

[...]

Arthur stood in the middle of the crossing.

The light changed again. Someone behind him went around — annoyed, in a hurry.

He reached the other side of the road. Stopped by the wall of a building. Watched Sati walk down the street — not turning, not slowing, just walking.

[She didn't recognize me.]

[She — didn't recognize me.]

The person who, seven years ago, saw "not from here" in him at first sight. The only person for whom it came without effort, without time, without the Grid — just a glance and a knowing. If even she doesn't see it — then there's nothing left to see.

[I've become from here.]

[I've become from here.]

He repeated it twice — as a check, as a confirmation. It was what he'd wanted. It was the goal. It was achieved.

He stood by the wall and felt nothing resembling victory.

He walked home.

[...]

At home it was warm. He undressed, put on the kettle, sat on the sofa. Outside, Sati had long since turned the corner and vanished from the city in which he was now one of the locals.

The kettle boiled.

He poured the tea.

Drank it.

PART IV. SILENCE

Chapter 11. A Seven-Year Habit Dies

February was the shortest month — and this year seemed especially short, as if someone had sped it up, removed a few days imperceptibly, and no one noticed.

Arthur lived evenly.

The library, books, people, conversations — it all went as it went, without effort, without the second layer, without counting. He became a part of the city's rhythm so organically that sometimes he was surprised himself — could this really have required work once? It seemed not. It seemed it had always been so.

[Warm.]

[Simply — warm.]

In mid-February Nora invited him to an exhibition. They went together, looked at photographs of other people's cities, drank mulled wine at the entrance. Arthur said he liked one work — a long shot of a harbor at dawn, water and light. Nora asked why.

"Beautiful," he said.

[Yes.]

Before, he'd have spoken of the composition, of how the light lies on the water at that angle at exactly this time of year, of the man in the left corner of the frame, almost invisible, who changes everything. Now — beautiful. That was true too.

{ He said "beautiful" — and smiled at Nora. I stood three paces off and heard it. Beautiful. One word. Before, that word wasn't enough for him — he always searched for something more precise, deeper, further. Now it's enough. I write this down and don't know what to do with it. }

That same evening — an ordinary evening, marked by nothing — Arthur came home, undressed, put on the kettle, sat on the sofa with a book.

He read. Page after page. A good book — he'd bought it a week ago, the seller in the shop recommended it, and he took it without long deliberation, simply took it.

[A good book.]

The kettle boiled. He got up, poured, came back to the sofa.

He read another hour.

At some point — between a page and the next page, between a sip of tea and the next sip — the time passed when he usually sat down to the transmission.

It passed — and nothing.

Not a decision not to sit down. Not an effort to skip it. Simply — the time passed, and the thought didn't come. The habit that for seven years had come on its own, at the same time, like breathing, like a heartbeat — didn't come.

[...]

A pause. The inner voice groped for something — the way a man gropes in the dark for an object that should be there, and doesn't find it.

[Today I didn't...]

[...]

The line didn't finish.

[...]

Arthur turned the page.

He read another half hour. Then closed the book, stretched, yawned. Looked out the window — February beyond the glass, the streetlamps, the rare passerby.

He went to wash up. Brushed his teeth. Lay down.

Outside it was almost spring — not spring yet, but already something in the air had changed, some tilt of the light.

He closed his eyes.

[]

The last square brackets in the book stood empty — not because there were no words inside, but because inside there was nothing that needed translating. The outer and the inner had become one. The gap vanished.

Arthur slept.

He slept better than he had in seven years.

Chapter 12. Bare Narrative

Spring came on a Thursday.

Not gradually — in one day: in the morning it was still winter, and by noon it had become something else. The air changed, the light changed, people in the streets unbuttoned their jackets and lifted their faces to the sky. The city exhaled.

Arthur woke at eight. Lay a few minutes, looked at the ceiling. Got up. Made coffee — not tea, today coffee, he simply felt like it. Drank it standing by the window, looking at the street.

A good morning.

Dressed, went out.

Outside it smelled of melting snow and something else — that particular spring note that appears on the first warm day and vanishes the next. He walked to the library by the usual route. Past the bakery, past the little park, past the stop with the blue bench.

By the park he stopped — not because he had to, he simply stopped. Looked at the trees. The buds were already swelling — small, tight, dark green. In a week they'd open.

Beautiful.

He walked on.

In the library it was quiet — a spring quiet, a little drowsy. He took the place by the third window, took out a book, opened it to the marked page. Page one hundred eighty-two. A good book — he was finishing it slowly, not because it was difficult, but because he didn't want it to end.

He read.

The librarian in glasses brought a new book-stand — asked whether he needed it. He said no, thank you. She nodded and left. An ordinary exchange.

At half past eleven Alex came — they hadn't arranged it, it just coincided. Sat down nearby, took out his laptop, greeted him under his breath. They sat side by side in silence — each with his own, side by side. Good.

At one they went to eat at the neighboring café. Soup, bread, tea. Alex told some story about work — a funny one about a colleague and a printer. Arthur laughed. The story was funny.

"You're cheerful today," said Alex.

"Spring," said Arthur.

"Yes," Alex agreed. "Spring."

After lunch they went back to the library — Alex for a short while, then left on errands. Arthur stayed. Read to page two hundred one. Put the book away. Sat a little, looking out the window at the street.

Passersby. Pigeons. A cyclist in a bright-yellow jacket.

He stood, dressed, went out.

Outside it was warmer than in the morning. He walked home without hurry, looking at the city. Shops, windows, children by the fountain — the fountain had been turned on for the first time that year, you could tell by how people stopped and looked.

He too stopped and looked.

The fountain worked. The water glittered in the sun.

He walked on.

At home he made dinner — a simple one, whatever was in the fridge. Ate. Washed the dishes. Sat with a book — a different one, just bought, not yet begun. Read the first page, the second, the third.

Interesting.

At ten he went to bed.

Outside was spring — real now, the first evening of real spring. The city lived, breathed, bloomed.

Arthur slept.

He was here. Truly here, without remainder, without the second layer, without the distance between himself and the world. He was one of the locals. He was from here.

He was quiet.

Terribly quiet.

Chapter 13. Melissa Cannot Read Him

She took out the notebooks on Sunday.

All seven years — in a box under the desk, forty-three notebooks of various sizes, some filled completely, some halfway, one — almost empty, only the first pages. She laid them out on the table in chronological order and opened the first.

The third of September. Seven years ago.

{ A man in the library, the place by the second window. Came at 9:14 — exactly, as if by a schedule that doesn't exist. Reads pages 44–67, the third time in a row. He doesn't reread — he repeats. The difference: repetition is a ritual, rereading is curiosity. He has a ritual. What is he ritualizing? I don't know yet. I write it down. Delay before answering the librarian — 2.3 seconds. It isn't hesitation. It's — a layer between the incoming and the outgoing. He translates. Who translates? }

She read slowly. Page after page, notebook after notebook. Outside a spring rain fell — the first real rain, not snow. She didn't notice.

The second year. The third.

{ He looks at the water differently than everyone. I can't explain the difference, but it's there — the quality of attention, the angle, something in the way the gaze passes through the surface to what lies beneath. As if he sees an architecture the rest don't see. I want to know what he sees. }

The fourth year. The fifth.

Her notes grew denser, more precise, more intimate — not in the sense of closeness, but in the sense of permission: she'd learned to see more finely, to distinguish details she used to miss. Seven years of observation had made her instrument very sharp.

{ Today he was at the harbor. I saw from far off — he stood at the pier and looked at the water. Before, he looked differently. Today — like everyone. I can't explain the difference, but it was there. Something went out of the way his gaze touches the world. I don't know what it means. But it's important. }

She set the notebook aside.

Stood. Walked around the room. Sat again.

Outside the rain intensified.

She took the very last notebook — the one almost empty. Opened it. Three pages of notes over the last months — sparse, short, with gaps where there used to be dense paragraphs. Fragments. Crossed-out lines. Questions without answers.

{ He holds his cup. ... He looks at a dog. ... I don't know what to write. }

She closed the notebook.

She sat a long time — hands on the table, before her forty-three notebooks with seven years of attention.

Then she stood, dressed, and went to Arthur's.

He opened the door quickly — hadn't been expecting her, but wasn't surprised. Invited her in, offered tea. She came in, sat on the sofa, took the cup.

Looked at him.

Professionally, detachedly — the way she'd looked for seven years. Searched for the pause of translation. Searched for the quality of attention, the angle of the gaze, the distance between him and the space. Searched for the trace of the one who translated.

Arthur told her something about the book he was reading. Interesting, he says, an unexpected ending. He smiled, held his cup, was here — fully here, without remainder.

{ I look at him and search for him. The one who was here for seven years. Who looked differently. Who translated. Who saw the architecture beneath the surface. He isn't there. Not hidden — not there. Not closed — not there. Simply not there. As if the man I knew how to read for seven years, and the man sitting before me with a cup of tea telling me about a book — are two different people, and one of them vanished, and the second knows nothing of it. }

"You look well," she said.

"Spring," he said, and smiled.

{ Spring. For him — spring. Blossoming. He's here, he's one of us, he's calm. Spring. For me — it's the day I understood I lost not him. He lives, breathes, drinks tea and tells me about books. I lost the ability to read him — because there's no longer anyone to read. He ceased to be a text. }

{ Seven years. Forty-three notebooks. I knew how to read one person in the world. Today I opened the book — and the pages are blank. Not because he fell silent. Because I forgot how to hear his frequency, when he himself stopped speaking on it. }

She finished the tea. Stood, said she'd only dropped in for a moment, thanks for the tea.

"Come by," said Arthur. "Always glad."

She went out.

On the stairs she stopped. Leaned against the wall. Closed her eyes.

The rain outside did not stop.

{ For seven years I was a receiver. I tuned to his frequency — and received. It was my work, my skill, my way of being near. Now the frequency is silent. And I stand on the stairs and think: if the receiver no longer receives — what happens to it? Where does the tuning go, when the signal disappears? }

She opened her eyes.

Went down the stairs. Out into the rain. Walked home.

Forty-three notebooks lay on the table — all the Arthur she knew. All the one who was no more.

And she carried him inside her — the way one carries the language of a country one will never return to.

Chapter 14. Who Transmits Now

The rain stopped by evening.

Melissa came home, took off her wet coat, hung it to dry. Went to the kitchen, put on the kettle. Stood and watched it heat — just watched, thinking of nothing in particular.

The kettle boiled.

She poured, took the cup, went to the table.

Forty-three notebooks lay where she'd left them — in chronological order, from first to last. She looked at them. Then pushed them aside — didn't put them away, just pushed them aside, to make room.

She took a clean notebook. A new one — bought a month ago, not yet opened. A dark-blue cover, thick paper.

Opened it to the first page.

Put the date.

{ Spring. The rain has stopped. }

She stopped.

Looked at the words. Before, after the date there always came a name — his name, then place, then time, then observation. Now there was no name. There was no observed. There was only the rain that had stopped, and the spring that had begun.

She wrote on.

{ I don't know what I'm doing. I know how to keep notes about another person. I don't know how to keep notes about the emptiness that remains when another person leaves — not physically, otherwise. But I've sat at this table every evening for seven years. Habit is a powerful thing. The body knows: evening, table, notebook. Let it be so. Let me write — no matter what. Let me simply — write. }

She wrote.

Not about him — or not only about him. About the rain. About the forty-three notebooks. About what it's like to look at one person for seven years and learn to see what's beneath the surface, and then discover that beneath the surface there's nothing anymore.

About the language of a country one will never return to.

About the fact that the language remained — inside her, alive, precise, gone nowhere. Only there's no one to speak it with now. Or — no one to speak it to. Or — to speak it into the void, as he did for seven years.

{ He transmitted a signal for seven years. Recipient — unknown. He didn't know whether there was anyone on the other side. He transmitted anyway. For seven years I received. I was on the other side. I was the receiver. Now the signal is silent. And I think — if I know how to receive, then I know how to do something else too. Something that makes receiving possible. Some organ that tunes to a frequency and hears what's beneath the surface. It didn't die with his signal. It's simply — out of work. Maybe it can work differently. }

She stopped.

Looked at what she'd written.

Then took the pen and wrote more — not words, something else. Not an observation about a person. An attempt to see the structure beneath the surface of what she felt — the way he saw the structure beneath the surface of the city, the crowd, the room. An attempt to apply his method — to herself, to this evening, to this silence.

It came out awkwardly. Imprecisely. Not at all like his.

But something was there.

One line — barely sketched, almost not monospace, rather her own type, her own angle:

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what remains of the receiver when the transmitter falls silent the receiver  
remains with all it managed to receive and with the ability to hear which has gone  
nowhere
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She closed the notebook.

Outside was spring — real, the first, warm. The city lived. Somewhere in another part of the city Arthur slept the peaceful sleep of a man who had at last become from here. His transmissions were silent. His registers were silent. He was quiet and whole and here.

Melissa sat at the table with a new notebook and a cup of cooled tea.

The signal did not break off.

It was searching for a new carrier.

It found one.

* * *

— END OF BOOK VII —

— SILENCE —

BOOK VIII · THE TRANSMITTER · FOLLOWS